

Breaking the Gandhian Knot

The poll debacle stirs calls for change in the Congress. **The rebels and others want unbiased organisational elections and an 'accountable leadership'.** Will the Gandhis give way?

By Kaushik Deka

On March 14, 1998, the Congress brought in Sonia Gandhi as president to save the party from imminent disintegration. The Gandhi surname was seen as a saviour—seven years after former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi's assassination, it still had immense electoral equity across India. Since then, Sonia has been the pivot of Congress politics, while her children Rahul and Priyanka joined the power nucleus in 2004 and 2019, respectively. In fact, for the first time in Congress history, three Gandhis are now simultaneously active in politics. It should have strengthened the Family's grip over the party. Instead, on March 13, exactly 22 years since Sonia's debut, the Congress matriarch was offering a complete family evacuation. "If there is a problem with the three of us, we are willing to make any sacrifice. We are very clear that the party comes first, and nobody is bigger than the party," she told the Congress Working Committee (CWC), the highest decision-making body of the party.

This offer of sacrifice, not the first from the Gandhis, came amid a growing discourse that the Family must take a back seat to save the party from being wiped off the political landscape of India. Since 2014, the Gandhis have presided over a series of electoral debacles, both at the national level and in the states. In the previous two Lok Sabha polls, the Congress could not go beyond double digits in a house of 543. The number of states it rules has shrunk to four—Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh on its own and Maharashtra and Jharkhand as junior partners in coalition governments—down from 13 in 2014. Just three days before the CWC meeting, the party had suffered a humiliating defeat in the assembly polls to five states, including Punjab, where it was in power.

As expected, the CWC requested Sonia to continue as interim president until organisational elections take place later this year and asked her to effect necessary organisational changes to take on political challenges (a similar resolution was passed in 2020 as well). However, this show of faith is restricted to Sonia. Several Congress stalwarts, apart from a ginger group popularly known as G23 who have openly sought organisational overhaul and accountable leadership, are wary of letting Rahul and Priyanka run the party—either in